

INDEPENDENT · READER-FUNDED · MADE IN CHATTANOOGA

The Scenic City Insider

Your weekly field guide to the people building Chattanooga.

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Hello, Scenic City.

You’re reading the very first issue of **The Scenic City Insider** — which means you’re early, and I’m grateful you’re here.

Here’s the whole idea: every Wednesday morning, a short, honest guide to the independent businesses, makers, and builders who make Chattanooga *Chattanooga* — the restaurants and breweries, the corner shops and coffee roasters, the founders quietly building something on Market Street and the Southside and across the river on Frazier.

And here’s my promise, the one this whole thing is built on: **we don’t take ads, and we don’t sell sponsorships.** Ever. No paid “best brunch” lists, no “featured” placements dressed up as picks. When the Insider tells you a place is worth your Saturday, it’s because we believe it — full stop. **We work for you, not for advertisers.**

What you *won’t* find here is crime, politics, or outrage. There’s plenty of that elsewhere. This is a place to fall back in love with your city and the people building it. Let’s go.

THE FIRST WORD

Why we’re starting with whiskey

In February, **Chattanooga Whiskey** was named **Best American Craft Producer** at the World Whiskies Awards — the second time in four years this city’s distillery has taken a global title. Worth a toast. But the award isn’t why I’m starting here.

Distilling was *illegal* in Hamilton County from 1909 until 2013. A pre-Prohibition Chattanooga had more than 30 distilleries lining Market Street; then the law shut it

all down for over a century. So when a couple of locals decided they wanted to make whiskey here again, they didn't just open a business — they ran a grassroots “Vote Whiskey” campaign and helped change the state law. Then they built the country's only standalone experimental distillery on the very street that used to be full of them.

That's the entire spirit of this newsletter in one bottle: **local people who saw something missing and built it back.** Those are the stories we're here for.

WHAT'S NEW AROUND TOWN

The openings, closings, and comings-and-goings — our favorite beat. (This section is only as good as your tips: see below.)

↗ **Now open — Elsie's Daughter** (Southside). Tucked into the Hotel Chalet at the Choo Choo, it's French-Belgian cooking with an Appalachian accent and a proper cocktail list. Date-night material.

🔄 **Changing hands — Zarzour's Café**, said to be Chattanooga's oldest restaurant, has new owners who plan to keep the name. We're rooting for a faithful return — and we'll let you know the day the screen door swings open again.

📍 **On our radar — Cafe del Sur** on Ringgold Road, opened by sisters Briana and Amairani Bautista. Coffee and pastries, and exactly the kind of family-built spot we'll keep championing.

Know a place that just opened — or one we're about to lose? **Hit reply.** The best tips in this newsletter come from you.

MEET A MAKER

Mad Priest Coffee Roasters

Downtown · founded 2015 · Michael & Cherita Rice

Before they roasted a single bean in Chattanooga, Michael and Cherita Rice were working in coffee in India, where conversations with refugees from Syria, Iran, and Iraq reshaped what they wanted to build. Mad Priest opened in 2015 with a mission stitched into the business model: **hire and train refugees resettling in Chattanooga**, pay a living wage, and put the shops on bus lines so the jobs are actually reachable.

Their first employee, Tariq, came to Chattanooga from Sudan and helped clean and paint the place before it opened. The coffee's genuinely good —

but it's the “why” behind the counter that keeps us coming back. This is what a local builder looks like.

THE INSIDER'S PICKS

What we'd do this week

Free or close to it. No agenda — just where we'd actually spend our time.

Wednesday • **Main Street Farmers Market** (Southside, by Finley Stadium, late afternoon). The city's food-focused, producer-run market — go hungry, leave with dinner.

Friday • **Nightfall** free concert downtown at Miller Park. Bring a chair; check the week's lineup before you go.

Saturday • Early morning at **Coolidge Park** on the Northshore — the antique carousel, the fountain, and a quiet stretch of the **Tennessee Riverwalk** — then coffee on Frazier. The light is perfect before 9am. (Yes, we're all counting the days until the Walnut Street Bridge reopens.)

Sunday • The **Chattanooga Market** at First Horizon Pavilion (11–4) — 100-plus local makers and growers, now in its 26th season. The beating heart of “made here.”

OPEN TAB

A few small things worth knowing.

A shop to know: Locals Only Gifts & Goods on Frazier stocks candles, hot sauce, pottery, and prints from 90+ Tennessee makers. Your one-stop “made nearby” gift run.

Civic-pride bite: the **MoonPie** was invented right here in 1917 and is still made by a family-owned Chattanooga bakery. A snack and a hometown legend.

Why “shop local” isn't just a bumper sticker: studies peg about **\$0.68 of every dollar** spent at a local independent staying in the community, versus roughly **\$0.43** at a chain. Where you spend is a small civic act.

One last thing

We don't take ads, and we never will. The Insider works for its readers — and that only works if its readers help it grow. Two tiny asks for issue one:

- ① **Forward this** to one person who loves this city as much as you do.
- ② **Hit reply** and tell me your favorite local spot — I read every single email, and you might see it featured.

Reader memberships are coming soon, for folks who want to help fund an independent, ad-free guide to Chattanooga. For now, your forward is worth more than any ad we'd ever run.

Yours in the Scenic City,

[Your Name]

Founder & Insider-in-Chief

The Scenic City Insider

Independent. Reader-funded. Made in Chattanooga.

No ads. No sponsorships. Just us and you.

Written by [Your Name] in Chattanooga, TN.

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